VARDRSEC / INDEPENDENT SECURITY RESEARCH

October 2026
Establishing the research baseline

WORKING DRAFT | Revision 0.1 | Partial month | One SSH sensor

This is the first report draft, not a completed monthly assessment. The reference values below come from an already-public delayed snapshot. They are not monthly totals. No actor attribution or confirmed malware-family claim is made.

A delayed 24-hour reference window

Published: 2026-10-15T02:00:09Z
Activity: 2026-10-14T01:00:00Z to 2026-10-15T01:00:00Z (end exclusive)

Observation	Count
Unique sessions	7,602
Unique source addresses	161
Authentication events	7,405
Command-input events	7,556
File-transfer events	151

Counts describe events at one decoy. Accepted honeypot logins do not imply access to the host. File-transfer events do not establish malware. Source addresses do not identify distinct people or campaigns.

Selected seven-day command patterns

2026-10-08T01:00:00Z to 2026-10-15T01:00:00Z (end exclusive)

```
cd ~ ; chattr -ia .ssh ; [EXECUTABLE] -ia .ssh
```

150 normalized command occurrences; not distinct attackers or successful actions.

```
cd ~ && rm -rf .ssh && mkdir .ssh && echo [SSH_KEY] >> .ssh/authorized_keys && chmod -R go= ~/.ssh && cd ~
```

146 normalized command occurrences; not distinct attackers or successful actions.

What the evidence supports

The authorized-keys template expresses an attempt to prepare an SSH directory and add a key. The attribute-change template contains a redacted executable; its identity and intent cannot be established from that template. The sensor records attempted behavior in an emulated environment.

TTP context and external research

SSH authorized-key modification is consistent with MITRE ATT&CK T1098.004. That is a behavioral mapping, not attribution. T1105 is useful context for future transfer analysis, not evidence of a specific campaign in this draft. Emerging-threat assessments and external campaign research remain pending for monthly close.

Malware analysis and publication

No captured samples or unreviewed hashes accompany this draft. Static triage records hashes, signatures, and bounded YARA heuristic matches without executing samples. Automated observations and human conclusions remain separate. A heuristic match is not a malware verdict. Public IOCs require evidence, context, confidence, and review.

Monthly archival and evidence limits

Incremental private archival saves calendar-month counts before the 30-day detailed retention limit. It incorporates late imports and deduplicates replayed logs. Captured samples remain outside automatic deletion. Monthly unique counts are not sums of daily unique counts.

At month close, review collection gaps, freeze a revision, analyze representative evidence, approve IOCs, and add dated primary-source research. One sensor and one protocol cannot measure global prevalence. Observation endpoints do not prove uptime; a partial month cannot support a monthly trend comparison.

Reproducible artifacts and references

Report, methodology and frozen public snapshot
https://vardrsec.com/report-2026-10

Reviewed technical artifacts and YARA rules
https://github.com/VardrSec/vardrsec-website/tree/main/research/2026-10

MITRE ATT&CK: SSH Authorized Keys
https://attack.mitre.org/techniques/T1098/004/

MITRE ATT&CK: Ingress Tool Transfer
https://attack.mitre.org/techniques/T1105/

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